TIME INTELLIGENCE MASTERCLASS

## WEEK 2

# PRIORITY INTELLIGENCE

DECIDING WHAT TRULY DESERVES YOUR TIME

**By**

**TOBAMS GROUP ACADEMY**

# Table of Contents

**INTRODUCTION ..... 4**

**1 Understanding the Relationship Between Time, Values, Priorities and Personal Goals ..... 6**

1. Understanding the Connection ..... 7
2. The Four Foundations of Priority Intelligence ..... 7
3. Understanding Priority Misalignment ..... 8
4. The Priority Alignment Principle ..... 8
5. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 9
6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PRIORITY ALIGNMENT AUDIT ..... 9
7. KEY TAKEAWAYS ..... 10

**2 Distinguishing Between Urgent, Important and Low-Value Activities ..... 11**

1. Understanding Urgency and Importance ..... 12
2. The Priority Decision Matrix ..... 12
3. Why Important Activities Are Frequently Postponed ..... 13
4. Applying the Matrix to Everyday Life ..... 13
5. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 14
6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR URGENT–IMPORTANT MATRIX ..... 15

**3 Identifying Meaningful Priorities Across Different Areas of Life ..... 16**

1. Understanding Multiple Life Priorities ..... 17
2. Understanding Life Priority Categories ..... 17
3. Priorities Are Not Always Equal ..... 18
4. The Three Levels of Personal Priorities ..... 18
5. Identifying Your Current Priority Season ..... 18
6. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 19
7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PERSONAL LIFE PRIORITY MAP ..... 19

**4 Managing Competing Responsibilities and Conflicting Expectations ..... 21**

1. Understanding Competing Demands ..... 22
2. Why Conflicting Expectations Create Time Pressure ..... 22
3. The Four Questions for Resolving Priority Conflicts ..... 23
5. Recognising When Support Is Necessary ..... 23
6. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 24
7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PRIORITY CONFLICT RESOLUTION PLAN ..... 25
8. KEY TAKEAWAYS ..... 25

**5 Understanding the Hidden Cost of Saying Yes to Too Many Commitments ..... 27**

1. Understanding the Cost of Commitment ..... 28

2. Why People Overcommit ..... 28
3. The Hidden Costs of Saying Yes ..... 29
4. The Commitment Cost Assessment ..... 29
5. Learning to Pause Before Committing ..... 29
6. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 30
7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - THE COST OF YES ..... 31
8. KEY TAKEAWAYS ..... 31
**6. Learning When to Eliminate, Reduce, Delegate, Defer or Decline Activities ..... 32**
1. Understanding the Need to Reconsider Activities ..... 33
2. The Five Decision Actions ..... 33
3. Understanding When Each Action Is Appropriate ..... 34
4. Avoiding the Trap of Doing Everything Yourself ..... 34
5. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 35
6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR FIVE-ACTION PRIORITY REVIEW ..... 35
**7 Developing a Personal Priority Hierarchy and Decision-Making Framework ..... 37**
1. Understanding a Personal Priority Hierarchy ..... 38
2. The Four-Level Priority Hierarchy ..... 38
3. Developing a Personal Priority Decision Framework ..... 39
4. The Priority Intelligence Decision Scorecard ..... 39
5. Turning Priorities into Weekly Decisions ..... 40
6. PERSONAL REFLECTION ..... 40
7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - DESIGN YOUR PERSONAL PRIORITY FRAMEWORK ..... 41
8. KEY TAKEAWAYS ..... 42
**INTEGRATED PRACTICAL APPLICATION ..... 43**
**CLOSING REFLECTION ..... 45**

**Central Question:**

What genuinely deserves my time?

# INTRODUCTION

**From Understanding Your Time to Deciding What Matters**

During Week 1, we explored Time Awareness. We examined our relationship with time, investigated the 168-hour week, distinguished between busyness and effectiveness, identified time leaks and considered how our habits, responsibilities and commitments influence time utilisation.

However, understanding where our time goes is only the beginning.

The next challenge is deciding **where our time should go**.

Every day, we face competing demands. Our employers expect results, our businesses require attention, our families need us, our relationships require investment, and our personal ambitions compete for space within an already demanding schedule.

The challenge is not always that we lack time. Sometimes, we struggle to distinguish between what is genuinely important, what appears urgent, what other people expect from us and what we have personally decided to prioritise.

This is where **Priority Intelligence** becomes essential.

Priority Intelligence is the ability to recognise what matters, evaluate competing demands and allocate time and attention in ways that support meaningful responsibilities, values and goals.

It is not about neglecting obligations or focusing exclusively on personal ambitions. Rather, it involves making informed decisions about how limited time should be distributed across different areas of life.

A person may be highly organised, complete numerous activities and maintain a full calendar, yet still make limited progress towards important goals. This happens when activities are managed efficiently without sufficiently questioning whether they deserve the time allocated to them.

**The central principle of Week 2 is simple:**

Effective time utilisation is not determined by how much you accomplish, but by how consistently your time supports what genuinely matters.

**Week 2 Learning Outcomes**

By the end of this week, participants should be able to:

1. Explain the relationship between personal values, priorities, goals and time allocation.
2. Distinguish urgent activities from important and low-value activities.

3. Identify meaningful priorities across different areas of life.
4. Manage competing responsibilities and conflicting expectations more intentionally.
5. Recognise the hidden consequences of excessive commitments.
6. Apply practical approaches to eliminating, reducing, delegating, deferring or declining activities.
7. Develop a personal priority hierarchy and decision-making framework.

# 1 Understanding the Relationship Between Time, Values, Priorities and Personal Goals

- Understanding the Connection
- The Four Foundations of Priority Intelligence
- Understanding Priority Misalignment
- The Priority Alignment Principle
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Your Priority Alignment Audit

## Central Question:

**Does the way I spend my time reflect what genuinely matters to me?**

## 1. Understanding the Connection

Time is one of the most visible expressions of our priorities.

What we repeatedly dedicate time to often reveals what receives our attention, even when those activities do not necessarily reflect what we consider most important.

For example, someone may describe personal health as a major priority but consistently postpone exercise, adequate rest and medical appointments. Another individual may value professional development but spend most discretionary time responding to less important requests.

These situations do not automatically indicate a lack of commitment. They may reflect competing obligations, limited resources or difficulty translating intentions into practical decisions.

Priority Intelligence begins by examining four interconnected concepts.

## 2. The Four Foundations of Priority Intelligence

| Foundation | Meaning | Example | Key Question |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Values** | Principles and beliefs that influence what matters to us. | Family, health, integrity, growth, financial security. | What is important to me? |
| **Goals** | Specific outcomes we want to achieve. | Complete a qualification, improve health or grow a business. | What am I trying to achieve? |
| **Priorities** | Responsibilities or activities that deserve attention relative to other demands. | Preparing for an examination or completing a critical project. | What deserves my attention now? |
| **Time Allocation** | How available time is actually distributed. | Spending five hours studying each week. | Where is my time going? |

These four elements should support one another.

**Values provide direction. Goals translate direction into outcomes. Priorities determine what deserves attention. Time allocation turns priorities into action.**

When these elements become disconnected, individuals may experience frustration despite remaining extremely busy.

## 3. Understanding Priority Misalignment

Priority misalignment occurs when the way we spend time consistently differs from what we consider important.

Consider three examples.

**Example 1: Professional Development**

A professional wants to progress into a leadership position but spends little time developing relevant capabilities.

**Example 2: Personal Relationships**

An individual considers family relationships important but repeatedly allows optional commitments to displace meaningful family time.

**Example 3: Business Growth**

An entrepreneur wants to expand a business but spends nearly every working hour managing routine administrative activities rather than developing customers, partnerships or strategic opportunities.

In each example, the individual may be working hard without allocating sufficient time to a stated priority.

The solution begins with identifying the gap between intention and action.

## 4. The Priority Alignment Principle

A useful approach is to examine three questions:

**What matters to me?**
Identify the values, responsibilities and goals that are genuinely significant.

**What receives my time?**
Examine how time is currently distributed.

**What needs to change?**
Identify realistic adjustments that would create better alignment.

This process should be approached with flexibility. Not every important priority can receive equal attention every day, and some essential responsibilities cannot be postponed.

The objective is not perfect alignment but **greater intentionality over time**.

## 5. PERSONAL REFLECTION

**Reflection Question 1**

What are the five things that matter most to you at this stage of your life?

Consider your family, career, business, education, health, relationships, personal development and other responsibilities.

.....

.....

**Reflection Question 2**

Which of these priorities currently receives the greatest amount of your time?

Is this allocation intentional or driven by circumstances?

.....

.....

**Reflection Question 3**

What important goal have you consistently postponed because other activities demand your attention?

.....

.....

## 6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PRIORITY ALIGNMENT AUDIT

**Duration: 10–15 minutes**

Identify five important areas of your life and evaluate how well your current time allocation reflects their importance.

| Important Area | Importance (1–5) | Current Attention (1–5) | Is There a Gap? | Adjustment Needed |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Health and wellbeing | | | | |
| Family and relationships | | | | |
| Career or business | | | | |
| Personal development | | | | |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Other personal priority | | | | |

**Rating Guide**

1 = Very Low
2 = Low
3 = Moderate
4 = High
5 = Very High

**Step 1:** Rate how important each area is to you.

**Step 2:** Rate how much meaningful attention it currently receives.

**Step 3:** Identify the largest differences between importance and attention.

**Step 4:** Select one realistic adjustment you can make this week.

**My Priority Alignment Commitment**

*One important area of my life that deserves greater attention is:*

.....

*One practical adjustment I will make is:*

.....

## 7. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Values influence what matters, while goals describe desired outcomes.
2. Priorities determine what deserves attention among competing demands.
3. Time allocation reveals how priorities are translated into everyday action.
4. Misalignment between values and time allocation can limit meaningful progress.
5. Priority Intelligence begins with recognising and addressing these gaps.

**FINAL THOUGHT**

Your calendar may not always reflect your values, but it can help reveal where your priorities need greater attention.

## 2 Distinguishing Between Urgent, Important and Low-Value Activities

- Understanding Urgency and Importance
- The Priority Decision Matrix
- Why Important Activities Are Frequently Postponed
- Applying the Matrix to Everyday Life
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Your Urgent–Important Matrix

## Central Question:

**Am I giving my time to what matters most or simply responding to what demands attention?**

## 1. Understanding Urgency and Importance

One of the most common challenges in time management is confusing urgency with importance.

Urgent activities demand immediate or near-term attention. Important activities contribute significantly to meaningful goals, responsibilities, wellbeing or outcomes.

An activity can be urgent without being particularly important. Equally, an important activity may not require immediate attention.

For example, an unexpected message may demand a quick response but contribute little to your most important goals.

Meanwhile, preparing for a professional qualification may be extremely important but lack an immediate deadline.

When urgent demands consistently dominate our schedules, important activities are often postponed until they become emergencies.

## 2. The Priority Decision Matrix

A useful framework is the **Urgent–Important Matrix**, commonly associated with the Eisenhower approach.

| Category | Description | Examples | Recommended Response |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Urgent and Important** | Requires timely attention and has significant consequences. | Critical deadline, family emergency, urgent operational problem. | Act promptly. |
| **Important but Not Urgent** | Contributes to long-term goals or essential wellbeing. | Learning, exercise, strategic planning, relationship development. | Schedule and protect time. |
| **Urgent but Less Important** | Requires attention but may contribute little to your major priorities. | Some routine requests, avoidable interruptions or minor administrative demands. | Assess, simplify, delegate or negotiate. |
| **Neither Urgent nor Important** | Offers limited value relative to the time consumed. | Unnecessary scrolling, repetitive low-value activities. | Reduce or eliminate where appropriate. |

This matrix is a decision-support tool rather than an absolute classification system.

An activity that is unimportant to one person may be essential to another. Context matters.

## 3. Why Important Activities Are Frequently Postponed

Important activities often require sustained attention and deliberate effort.

They may not create the immediate pressure associated with urgent tasks.

For example:

- Improving physical fitness.
- Developing professional capabilities.
- Building financial security.
- Strengthening relationships.
- Planning business growth.
- Completing a personal project.

Because these activities can often be postponed without immediate consequences, they may repeatedly lose out to short-term demands.

Over time, however, postponement can create significant consequences.

**Priority Intelligence requires protecting time for important activities before they become urgent problems.**

## 4. Applying the Matrix to Everyday Life

Imagine you have four activities competing for your attention:

1. Completing a client proposal due tomorrow.
2. Beginning a professional development course.
3. Responding to a non-urgent message.
4. Browsing social media without a specific purpose.

The proposal is urgent and important.

Professional development may be important but not urgent.

The message may require a response but not immediate attention.

Unplanned browsing may be low-value if it displaces activities you intended to complete.

The objective is not to eliminate leisure or respond slowly to every message. It is to make deliberate decisions based on context and consequences.

## 5. PERSONAL REFLECTION

**Reflection Question 1**

How frequently do urgent requests interrupt activities you consider important?

.....

**Reflection Question 2**

What important activity have you postponed because it does not have an immediate deadline?

.....

**Reflection Question 3**

Which recurring activities create a sense of urgency without contributing significantly to meaningful outcomes?

.....

## 6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR URGENT–IMPORTANT MATRIX

**Duration: 10–15 minutes**

Identify eight activities currently competing for your attention.

Classify them using the following matrix.

| | **URGENT** | **NOT URGENT** |
|---|---|---|
| **IMPORTANT** | **ACT NOW** - Activities requiring prompt action. | **SCHEDULE** - Activities that deserve protected time. |
| **LESS IMPORTANT** | **ASSESS OR DELEGATE** - Activities that may be simplified or renegotiated. | **REDUCE OR ELIMINATE** - Activities providing limited value. |

**Step 1:** List your eight activities.

**Step 2:** Place each activity in the appropriate category.

**Step 3:** Identify one important but non-urgent activity that needs attention.

**Step 4:** Schedule a realistic time to begin it.

**My Most Important Non-Urgent Activity**

Activity: .....

When I will begin: .....

First action: .....

## 7. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Urgency and importance are different.
2. Immediate demands should not automatically determine priorities.
3. Important but non-urgent activities require deliberate protection.
4. The priority matrix helps distinguish meaningful activities from unnecessary demands.
5. Effective prioritisation considers consequences, responsibilities and long-term value.

## FINAL THOUGHT

Not everything demanding your attention deserves to become your priority.

## 3 Identifying Meaningful Priorities Across Different Areas of Life

- Understanding Multiple Life Priorities
- Understanding Life Priority Categories
- Priorities Are Not Always Equal
- The Three Levels of Personal Priorities
- Identifying Your Current Priority Season
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Your Personal Life Priority Map

## Central Question:

**How do I decide what deserves attention when several areas of my life matter?**

## 1. Understanding Multiple Life Priorities

Prioritisation becomes more complex when several important areas of life compete for limited time.

A professional may need to meet demanding work expectations while maintaining family relationships, personal health and professional development.

An entrepreneur may need to balance business growth, financial responsibilities, relationships and personal wellbeing.

A student may be managing academic responsibilities, employment, family obligations and personal ambitions.

The challenge is not necessarily deciding which area matters most forever. It is deciding **what deserves appropriate attention at this particular stage of life**.

Priorities change as circumstances change.

An individual caring for a newborn may need a different time allocation from someone preparing for a professional examination or launching a business.

## 2. Understanding Life Priority Categories

The following categories provide a useful starting point.

| Life Dimension | Typical Priorities | Potential Consequence of Neglect |
|---|---|---|
| **Health and Wellbeing** | Sleep, exercise, recovery, medical care. | Reduced wellbeing and personal capacity. |
| **Family and Relationships** | Caregiving, communication, quality time. | Relationship strain or unmet responsibilities. |
| **Career and Professional Development** | Work performance, learning, career progression. | Reduced professional growth. |
| **Business and Financial Responsibilities** | Business operations, income, budgeting, financial planning. | Financial pressure or missed opportunities. |
| **Personal Development** | Learning, skills, reflection and personal goals. | Stagnation or unfulfilled aspirations. |
| **Community and Personal Interests** | Volunteering, recreation, spiritual life or hobbies. | Reduced fulfilment or connection. |

These categories are illustrative. Participants should adapt them to their own circumstances and values.

## 3. Priorities Are Not Always Equal

One common mistake is assuming that every important area of life must receive equal time.

In practice, meaningful priorities require different levels of attention.

For example, preparing for an examination may temporarily require additional study time.

A family health issue may require increased caregiving.

A major business deadline may demand a short period of intensive work.

The important distinction is between **temporary adjustments and persistent neglect**.

A temporary imbalance may be necessary. A prolonged pattern of ignoring important needs may require reconsideration.

## 4. The Three Levels of Personal Priorities

A useful approach is to organise priorities into three levels.

| Priority Level | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Essential Priorities** | Responsibilities and needs that must receive appropriate attention. | Health needs, dependent care, essential work obligations. |
| **Development Priorities** | Activities that support future progress and meaningful goals. | Professional qualifications, business development, skill acquisition. |
| **Enrichment Priorities** | Activities that contribute to fulfilment, relationships and quality of life. | Recreation, hobbies, community engagement and personal interests. |

These levels should not be treated as a rigid ranking of human value. For example, recreation may become essential to someone's wellbeing.

The framework simply helps participants consider different types of priorities and make more informed decisions.

## 5. Identifying Your Current Priority Season

Ask yourself:

- What responsibilities require my attention right now?
- What important goal am I actively pursuing?
- Which area of my life needs additional support?
- What can reasonably receive less attention for a limited period?

- What must not be neglected?

These questions help establish priorities that reflect current circumstances rather than unrealistic expectations.

## 6. PERSONAL REFLECTION

**Reflection Question 1**

Which three areas of your life currently require the greatest attention?

.....

**Reflection Question 2**

Are you trying to give equal attention to activities that require different levels of priority?

.....

**Reflection Question 3**

Which important area of your life needs greater protection over the next three months?

.....

## 7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PERSONAL LIFE PRIORITY MAP

**Duration: 15 minutes**

Complete the table below.

| Life Area | Current Priority (High/Medium/Low) | Why It Matters | Attention Required | One Practical Action |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Health and wellbeing | | | | |
| Family and relationships | | | | |
| Career or business | | | | |
| Financial responsibilities | | | | |
| Personal development | | | | |
| Other important area | | | | |

**Step 1:** Identify your current priority level for each area.

**Step 2:** Explain why each area matters.

**Step 3:** Determine whether it requires immediate, regular or occasional attention.

**Step 4:** Select your three most significant priorities for the next 30 days.

**My Top Three Priorities**

| Priority | Why It Matters | Action I Will Take |
|---|---|---|
| Priority 1 | | |
| Priority 2 | | |
| Priority 3 | | |

## 8. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Meaningful priorities exist across several areas of life.
2. Different responsibilities require different levels of attention.
3. Priorities change as circumstances and life stages change.
4. Temporary imbalance is sometimes necessary, but persistent neglect deserves attention.
5. Priority Intelligence involves identifying what matters now while remaining mindful of long-term responsibilities.

## FINAL THOUGHT

Prioritisation is not about choosing one part of your life and ignoring everything else. It is about giving appropriate attention to what matters at the right time.

## 4 Managing Competing Responsibilities and Conflicting Expectations

- Understanding Competing Demands
- Why Conflicting Expectations Create Time Pressure
- The Four Questions for Resolving Priority Conflicts
- Recognising When Support Is Necessary
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Your Priority Conflict Resolution Plan

## Central Question:

**What should I do when several important responsibilities demand my attention simultaneously?**

### 1. Understanding Competing Demands

Many people struggle with time not because they lack priorities, but because they have several legitimate priorities competing for attention.

For example, a manager may need to complete an urgent report while supporting team members.

A parent may need to attend an important work meeting while managing unexpected family responsibilities.

A business owner may need to serve customers while resolving operational challenges.

These situations create competing demands because two or more responsibilities require time, attention or resources within the same period.

The solution is not always to work faster. It may require evaluating consequences, negotiating expectations, adjusting schedules or seeking appropriate support.

### 2. Why Conflicting Expectations Create Time Pressure

Conflicting expectations arise when different people or responsibilities require outcomes that are difficult to achieve simultaneously.

| Source of Conflict | Example | Potential Response |
|---|---|---|
| **Work and Family** | A late meeting conflicts with an important family responsibility. | Communicate early and explore alternative arrangements. |
| **Multiple Work Priorities** | Two managers request urgent deliverables. | Clarify deadlines and agree on priorities. |
| **Business Responsibilities** | Customer demands conflict with operational tasks. | Assess consequences and redistribute activities. |
| **Personal Goals and Obligations** | Study time conflicts with recurring commitments. | Review commitments and establish protected study periods. |
| **Unexpected Events** | An emergency disrupts a planned schedule. | Reassess priorities and adjust expectations. |

The key principle is that not every conflict can be resolved through individual effort alone.

Some require cooperation, negotiation or changes to the wider system.

## 3. The Four Questions for Resolving Priority Conflicts

When two responsibilities compete, consider four questions.

**1. What are the consequences of delay?**

Identify which activity has the most significant consequences if postponed.

**2. What is genuinely time-sensitive?**

Determine whether both activities require immediate attention or whether one deadline is flexible.

**3. What can be negotiated or shared?**

Consider whether expectations, responsibilities or resources can be adjusted.

**4. What decision best protects essential responsibilities and meaningful outcomes?**

Choose the most appropriate response based on the available information.

**4. Managing Expectations Through Communication**

Many priority conflicts become more difficult because expectations are not discussed early enough.

For example, instead of accepting two conflicting deadlines, an employee might explain:

“I can complete the first deliverable today or prioritise the second request. Which outcome is more important?”

Similarly, someone managing family and personal commitments may need to communicate when they are available and where support is required.

Effective prioritisation therefore involves not only personal decisions but also clear communication.

## 5. Recognising When Support Is Necessary

Some demands cannot reasonably be managed by one person.

If responsibilities consistently exceed available capacity, the appropriate response may involve:

- Requesting additional resources.
- Redistributing responsibilities.
- Renegotiating deadlines.
- Seeking practical assistance.

- Reviewing unrealistic expectations.

**Priority Intelligence includes recognising when a problem requires support rather than simply greater personal effort.**

## 6. PERSONAL REFLECTION

### Reflection Question 1

Which two responsibilities most frequently compete for your time?

.....

### Reflection Question 2

How do you currently decide what receives attention when expectations conflict?

.....

### Reflection Question 3

Is there a recurring situation where better communication or additional support could reduce time pressure?

.....

## 7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR PRIORITY CONFLICT RESOLUTION PLAN

**Duration: 10–15 minutes**

Identify one current conflict between two responsibilities.

| Decision Factor | Responsibility A | Responsibility B |
|---|---|---|
| What is required? | | |
| Deadline or time sensitivity | | |
| Consequence of delay | | |
| Importance to current priorities | | |
| Can expectations be adjusted? | | |
| Support or resources available | | |

**Step 1:** Describe the competing responsibilities.

**Step 2:** Compare their importance, urgency and consequences.

**Step 3:** Identify possible adjustments.

**Step 4:** Decide what action is most appropriate.

**Step 5:** Identify any conversation needed to communicate your decision.

**My Priority Decision**

.....

**The person I need to communicate with, if applicable:**

.....

**The action I will take:**

.....

## 8. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Competing responsibilities may all be legitimate and important.
2. Priority conflicts require evaluating consequences, urgency and available resources.
3. Clear communication can prevent unnecessary pressure.
4. Negotiation and shared responsibilities may be more effective than attempting to do everything.
5. Time Intelligence includes recognising personal and structural capacity limitations.

## FINAL THOUGHT

When everything appears important, the solution is not always to do more. Sometimes, it is to make clearer decisions and communicate them effectively.

## 5 Understanding the Hidden Cost of Saying Yes to Too Many Commitments

- Understanding the Cost of Commitment
- Why People Overcommit
- The Hidden Costs of Saying Yes
- The Commitment Cost Assessment
- Learning to Pause Before Committing
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - The Cost of Yes

## Central Question:

**What am I giving up every time I agree to another commitment?**

### 1. Understanding the Cost of Commitment

Every commitment requires something from us.

It may require time, attention, preparation, emotional energy, financial resources or ongoing responsibility.

When we agree to something, we are not simply adding an activity to our schedule. We are also reducing the time and capacity available for other activities.

This is closely related to the concept of **opportunity cost**.

Opportunity cost is the value of the next-best alternative we give up when making a decision.

For example, agreeing to an additional evening meeting may mean giving up time intended for study, rest or family.

The meeting may be valuable, but its true cost includes the alternative activity that can no longer take place.

### 2. Why People Overcommit

Overcommitment can occur for several reasons.

| Reason | Typical Thinking | Potential Consequence |
|---|---|---|
| **Desire to Help** | “I don't want to disappoint anyone.” | Taking on more than is sustainable. |
| **Fear of Missing Out** | “This opportunity may never come again.” | Accepting activities without sufficient evaluation. |
| **Difficulty Setting Boundaries** | “It is easier to agree than explain.” | Reduced control over available time. |
| **Overestimating Capacity** | “I can fit one more thing into my week.” | Unrealistic scheduling and fatigue. |
| **Social or Professional Pressure** | “People expect me to be available.” | Commitments driven by external expectations. |
| **Unclear Priorities** | “Everything seems important.” | Difficulty deciding what to decline. |

Not all commitments are freely chosen. Financial needs, employment conditions and caregiving responsibilities may substantially limit available choices.

The purpose is to improve decisions where flexibility exists.

## 3. The Hidden Costs of Saying Yes

The impact of an additional commitment may extend beyond the time required to complete it.

**Time Cost**

How many hours will the activity require, including preparation and follow-up?

**Attention Cost**

Will the activity interrupt concentration or reduce the ability to focus on other priorities?

**Energy Cost**

How physically or mentally demanding will the commitment be?

**Opportunity Cost**

What important activity may need to be postponed or abandoned?

**Recovery Cost**

Will the commitment reduce necessary rest or recovery?

## 4. The Commitment Cost Assessment

Before accepting a new optional responsibility, consider the following.

| Question | Why It Matters |
|---|---|
| What exactly am I agreeing to? | Clarifies the full scope of the commitment. |
| How much time will it require? | Prevents underestimating the workload. |
| Does it align with my current priorities? | Establishes relevance and value. |
| What will I need to postpone? | Reveals opportunity cost. |
| Do I have sufficient capacity? | Tests whether the commitment is realistic. |
| Can the scope or timing be adjusted? | Identifies alternative arrangements. |

## 5. Learning to Pause Before Committing

One practical habit is to avoid immediately agreeing to non-urgent requests.

For example:

“Thank you for considering me. Let me review my existing commitments and confirm whether I can take this on.”

This creates space for a deliberate decision.

It is not a refusal. It is an opportunity to evaluate the request properly.

**A thoughtful yes is often more valuable than an automatic yes.**

## 6. PERSONAL REFLECTION

### Reflection Question 1

When did you last agree to something that you later regretted because of the time required?

.....

### Reflection Question 2

What makes it difficult for you to decline requests or negotiate commitments?

.....

### Reflection Question 3

Which existing commitment currently requires more time or energy than you originally anticipated?

.....

## 7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - THE COST OF YES

**Duration: 10–15 minutes**

Identify three current or proposed commitments.

| Commitment | Time Required | Value or Benefit | What It Displaces | Decision |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Commitment 1 | | | | |
| Commitment 2 | | | | |
| Commitment 3 | | | | |

**Step 1:** Estimate the full time requirement for each commitment.

**Step 2:** Identify its benefits and importance.

**Step 3:** Consider what other activity may be displaced.

**Step 4:** Decide whether to maintain, renegotiate or decline the commitment, where appropriate.

**Your Personal Boundary Statement**

Complete the following:

**"Before accepting a new optional commitment, I will ask myself..."**

.....

.....

## 8. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Every commitment requires time, energy or other resources.
2. Saying yes to one activity can reduce capacity for another.
3. Opportunity cost helps reveal the hidden consequences of decisions.
4. Overcommitment can result from external pressures as well as personal habits.
5. Deliberate commitment decisions support sustainable time utilisation.

**FINAL THOUGHT**

Every yes has a cost. Priority Intelligence helps you decide whether that cost is worth paying.

## 6. Learning When to Eliminate, Reduce, Delegate, Defer or Decline Activities

- Understanding the Need to Reconsider Activities
- The Five Decision Actions
- Understanding When Each Action Is Appropriate
- Avoiding the Trap of Doing Everything Yourself
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Your Five-Action Priority Review

## Central Question:

**What should I do with activities that no longer deserve the time they receive?**

## 1. Understanding the Need to Reconsider Activities

Effective prioritisation is not simply about identifying important activities. It also requires deciding what to do with less important, unnecessary or poorly timed commitments.

Many people continue activities because they have become habitual, because others expect them or because they have already invested time in them.

However, maintaining every existing activity can leave little capacity for new priorities.

Priority Intelligence requires the willingness to review activities and make appropriate adjustments.

One useful approach is the **Five Decision Actions**:

**Eliminate → Reduce → Delegate → Defer → Decline**

These actions provide different ways to manage competing demands.

## 2. The Five Decision Actions

| Action | Meaning | When to Use It | Practical Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Eliminate** | Stop an activity entirely. | When it is unnecessary and offers little value. | Discontinue a redundant weekly report. |
| **Reduce** | Decrease the frequency, duration or scope. | When an activity is useful but consumes excessive time. | Shorten a recurring meeting from 60 to 30 minutes. |
| **Delegate** | Transfer appropriate responsibility to someone capable and authorised. | When the activity can be completed effectively by another person. | Assign routine administrative work to a trained team member. |
| **Defer** | Move an activity to a more appropriate time. | When it matters but is not currently urgent. | Postpone an optional project until a critical deadline passes. |
| **Decline** | Choose not to accept a new request or commitment. | When it does not align with priorities or available capacity. | Politely decline an optional event during an examination period. |

These actions are not interchangeable.

For example, delegating a task requires considering competence, authority, resources and accountability.

Similarly, deferring an essential responsibility may create serious consequences.

The decision must therefore reflect the nature of the activity.

## 3. Understanding When Each Action Is Appropriate

**Eliminate: Is This Activity Still Necessary?**

Some activities continue long after their original purpose has disappeared.

Ask whether the activity is still required and whether stopping it would create significant consequences.

**Reduce: Can the Same Value Be Achieved With Less Time?**

An activity may remain valuable but require less time or frequency.

For example, a weekly one-hour meeting may achieve the same purpose in 30 minutes with better preparation.

**Delegate: Must I Personally Complete This Activity?**

Delegation can create capacity, but it should not simply transfer an unreasonable workload to another person.

Appropriate delegation requires clear expectations, necessary resources and accountability.

**Defer: Does This Need Attention Now?**

Some worthwhile activities can be postponed without undermining their value.

Deferral should involve a deliberate future review rather than indefinite avoidance.

**Decline: Should I Accept This Commitment?**

Declining optional requests may be necessary to protect existing responsibilities.

A respectful refusal can preserve relationships while maintaining appropriate boundaries.

## 4. Avoiding the Trap of Doing Everything Yourself

Some individuals struggle to delegate because they believe tasks will only be completed properly if they personally undertake them.

Others continue unnecessary activities because stopping them feels uncomfortable.

Priority Intelligence encourages a different approach.

Instead of asking, *“How can I fit everything into my schedule?”* ask:

**“Which activities genuinely require my time, and which could be handled differently?”**

## 5. PERSONAL REFLECTION

**Reflection Question 1**

Which recurring activity could you eliminate without creating significant negative consequences?

.....

**Reflection Question 2**

What responsibility could be simplified, reduced or appropriately shared?

.....

**Reflection Question 3**

What optional request or commitment do you need to reconsider?

.....

## 6. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - YOUR FIVE-ACTION PRIORITY REVIEW

**Duration: 15 minutes**

Identify five activities currently consuming your time.

| Activity | Current Time Requirement | Value Provided | Decision Action | Next Step |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Activity 1 | | | | |
| Activity 2 | | | | |
| Activity 3 | | | | |
| Activity 4 | | | | |
| Activity 5 | | | | |

**Step 1:** Review the importance of each activity.

**Step 2:** Select the most appropriate action: eliminate, reduce, delegate, defer or decline.

**Step 3:** Consider whether the decision affects other people or responsibilities.

**Step 4:** Identify the communication or preparation required.

**Step 5:** Implement one adjustment during the next seven days.

**My Priority Improvement Decision**

**The activity I will reconsider:**

.....

**The action I will take:**

.....

**The time or capacity I expect to create:**

.....

**How I will use that capacity more intentionally:**

.....

## 7. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Prioritisation requires reviewing existing activities, not only adding new ones.
2. Eliminating unnecessary work can create capacity for meaningful priorities.
3. Reducing activities may preserve their value while lowering time demands.
4. Delegation requires appropriate authority, resources and accountability.
5. Deferring and declining activities can be necessary for sustainable commitments.

## FINAL THOUGHT

Making time for what matters often begins with reconsidering what no longer deserves your time.

# 7 Developing a Personal Priority Hierarchy and Decision-Making Framework

- Understanding a Personal Priority Hierarchy
- The Four-Level Priority Hierarchy
- Developing a Personal Priority Decision Framework
- The Priority Intelligence Decision Scorecard
- Turning Priorities into Weekly Decisions
- Personal Reflection
- Practical Exercise - Design Your Personal Priority Framework

**Central Question:**

**How can I consistently decide what deserves my time?**

## 1. Understanding a Personal Priority Hierarchy

A personal priority hierarchy is a structured way of organising responsibilities, goals and activities according to their importance and relevance.

It helps individuals make decisions when several activities compete for attention.

Without a clear hierarchy, priorities may change constantly in response to interruptions, external expectations or immediate pressure.

For example, an individual may begin the day intending to complete an important project but repeatedly shift attention to less important requests.

A priority hierarchy provides a reference point for evaluating these demands.

It does not mean every decision must follow a rigid ranking. Emergencies, changing circumstances and new information may require priorities to change.

The objective is to develop a consistent approach to making thoughtful decisions.

## 2. The Four-Level Priority Hierarchy

| Priority Level | Description | Examples | Recommended Approach |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Level 1 - Essential Responsibilities** | Obligations and needs that require appropriate attention. | Health needs, dependent care, critical work obligations. | Protect and fulfil responsibly. |
| **Level 2 - High-Impact Priorities** | Activities that contribute significantly to important goals. | Strategic projects, professional development, meaningful personal goals. | Schedule and protect time. |
| **Level 3 - Supporting Activities** | Necessary activities that enable daily responsibilities. | Routine administration, household organisation, general correspondence. | Organise, simplify or share where possible. |
| **Level 4 - Optional Activities** | Activities with greater flexibility in timing or participation. | Some social events, optional meetings or discretionary activities. | Evaluate based on value and capacity. |

These levels describe decision priorities, not the worth of the activities or people involved.

For example, leisure and recreation may be essential for wellbeing and should not automatically be classified as low priority.

## 3. Developing a Personal Priority Decision Framework

Before committing time to an activity, consider five questions.

**Question 1: Is It Necessary?**

Does this activity fulfil an essential responsibility or important need?

**Question 2: Is It Important?**

Does it contribute meaningfully to my current goals, values or responsibilities?

**Question 3: Is It Time-Sensitive?**

What are the consequences of postponing it?

**Question 4: Do I Have the Capacity?**

Can I realistically complete it without creating unsustainable pressure?

**Question 5: What Is the Best Decision?**

Should I act, schedule, simplify, delegate, defer or decline?

## 4. The Priority Intelligence Decision Scorecard

For non-emergency activities, a simple scorecard can help clarify competing choices.

Rate each factor from 1 to 5.

| Decision Factor | Guiding Question | Score (1–5) |
|---|---|---|
| **Importance** | How significantly does this activity contribute to a meaningful priority? | |
| **Time Sensitivity** | How serious are the consequences of delaying it? | |
| **Impact** | What meaningful benefit or outcome could it produce? | |
| **Alignment** | How closely does it support my values, responsibilities or goals? | |
| **Feasibility** | How realistic is completion with my current resources and capacity? | |
| **TOTAL** | | **/25** |

A higher score suggests that the activity may deserve stronger consideration.

However, the score is not a mathematical instruction to proceed. An essential obligation may require attention even when feasibility is low, while a high-scoring optional activity may still need to be postponed.

The scorecard supports judgement rather than replacing it.

## 5. Turning Priorities into Weekly Decisions

Identifying priorities is only useful when they influence everyday behaviour.

A simple weekly approach is to:

1. Review essential responsibilities.
2. Identify three meaningful outcomes for the week.
3. Allocate realistic time to those outcomes.
4. Consider potential conflicts and interruptions.
5. Review progress and adjust where necessary.

This creates a connection between longer-term priorities and daily actions.

**Priority Intelligence becomes practical when your decisions, calendar and commitments begin to reflect what you have identified as important.**

## 6. PERSONAL REFLECTION

### Reflection Question 1

How do you currently decide which activities deserve your time?

.....

### Reflection Question 2

What influences your priorities most: personal values, important goals, deadlines or other people's expectations?

.....

### Reflection Question 3

What would change if you consistently evaluated commitments before accepting them?

.....

## 7. PRACTICAL EXERCISE - DESIGN YOUR PERSONAL PRIORITY FRAMEWORK

**Duration: 15–20 minutes**

### Step 1 - Identify Your Current Priorities

List six activities or responsibilities that require attention during the next seven days.

| Activity or Responsibility | Priority Level (1–4) | Why It Matters | Action Required |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | | | |
| 2. | | | |
| 3. | | | |
| 4. | | | |
| 5. | | | |
| 6. | | | |

### Step 2 - Select Your Top Three Outcomes

Identify the three most meaningful outcomes you want to achieve this week.

| Priority Outcome | First Action | Time Required | When Will I Act? |
|---|---|---|---|
| Outcome 1 | | | |
| Outcome 2 | | | |
| Outcome 3 | | | |

### Step 3 - Identify Potential Obstacles

What could prevent you from completing these priorities?

.....

.....

### Step 4 - Establish Your Decision Rules

Complete the following statements.

**Before accepting a new commitment, I will:**

.....

**When two important responsibilities conflict, I will:**

.....

**When an activity no longer provides sufficient value, I will:**

.....

**To protect time for meaningful priorities, I will:**

.....

**Step 5 - Create Your Personal Priority Statement**

Complete this statement:

**"My approach to Priority Intelligence is to allocate my time according to..."**

.....

.....

## 8. KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. A priority hierarchy helps organise competing responsibilities and goals.
2. Essential obligations, high-impact priorities, supporting activities and optional commitments require different decisions.
3. Effective prioritisation considers importance, urgency, impact, alignment and capacity.
4. Decision frameworks should support judgement rather than replace it.
5. Consistent weekly reviews help translate priorities into meaningful action.

### FINAL THOUGHT

Priority Intelligence is the ability to make deliberate decisions about what deserves your time, even when many other things demand it.

# INTEGRATED PRACTICAL APPLICATION

**YOUR PERSONAL PRIORITY INTELLIGENCE ACTION PLAN**

**Duration: 20–30 minutes**

You have now explored all seven dimensions of Priority Intelligence covered in Week 2.

The final activity brings together your learning and helps you develop a practical approach to prioritisation.

**Part A - Review Your Current Priorities**

Identify five major activities or responsibilities currently requiring your attention.

| Current Activity | Why It Matters | Current Time Allocation | Desired Adjustment |
|---|---|---|---|
| Activity 1 | | | |
| Activity 2 | | | |
| Activity 3 | | | |
| Activity 4 | | | |
| Activity 5 | | | |

**Part B - Identify Your Priority Challenges**

Review the following statements.

| Statement | Rarely | Sometimes | Often |
|---|---|---|---|
| I spend time on activities that do not support my important goals. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| Urgent requests regularly displace meaningful priorities. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| I struggle to decide between competing responsibilities. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| I accept commitments without considering their full cost. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| I find it difficult to decline optional requests. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| My weekly activities do not consistently reflect my priorities. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

These responses are intended for reflection rather than formal scoring.

**My greatest Priority Intelligence challenge is:**

.....

.....

**Part C - Your Seven-Day Priority Improvement Plan**

| Priority Improvement Area | Action I Will Take | When | How I Will Measure Progress |
|---|---|---|---|
| Clarifying priorities | | | |
| Protecting important activities | | | |
| Managing competing demands | | | |
| Reviewing commitments | | | |
| Improving weekly decisions | | | |

**Part D - Your Personal Commitment**

Complete the following statement:

**"Over the next seven days, I will become more intentional about my priorities by..."**

.....

.....

## CLOSING REFLECTION

**What Have You Discovered About Your Priorities?**

Throughout Week 2, we have examined how values and goals influence priorities, distinguished urgency from importance, explored competing responsibilities and considered the consequences of excessive commitments.

We have also introduced practical approaches to reviewing activities and developing a personal priority hierarchy.

Before moving into Week 3, reflect on the following questions.

**1. What is the most important thing I have learned about my priorities this week?**

.....

.....

**2. Which activity or commitment currently receives more time than it deserves?**

.....

.....

**3. Which important goal or responsibility needs greater protection?**

.....

.....

**4. What one decision will I make differently because of what I have learned?**

.....

.....

**YOUR WEEK 2 PERSONAL COMMITMENT**

**"I will stop allowing every demand on my time to become a priority. I will make more deliberate decisions about what deserves my attention, based on my responsibilities, values, goals and available capacity."**

**LOOKING AHEAD - WEEK 3**

**CAPACITY INTELLIGENCE**

**Managing Your Energy, Commitments and Personal Capacity**

**Central Question: What can I realistically carry and accomplish well?**

In Week 3, we will examine the relationship between available time, personal energy, workload and realistic capacity.

Participants will explore why having time available does not necessarily mean having the capacity to undertake additional responsibilities.

The week will focus on recognising overcommitment, understanding personal energy patterns, establishing sustainable boundaries and creating capacity for meaningful priorities.

**Week 3 will help participants move from deciding what matters to understanding what they can realistically manage.**

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